Preparing to be a Sex Coach:
Core Skills for Intimacy & Sex Coaches

Onika Henry (Clinical Sexologist & Sex Educator)

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- Notice your somatic (body-based) response to the following case
- Then notice your emotional response
- Next, notice your thoughts.



2

Case John

Dr Patti Britton writes:

John was an unusual client. It was the mid 1990s, the pre-Viagra era. Aged 64, he had suffered from surgical removal of his cancerous prostate, leaving him with erectile difficulties, a grave sense of loss of his manhood, no ejaculate, and embarrassment that left him lonely and afraid to date. Our sex coaching involved helping him reframe his sense of masculinity by eliciting from him where he truly was a man in other ways. It included one "extraordinary" session early on, when John felt it would be helpful to bring in his new erection pump. John removed his trousers, and revealed his slightly erect penis to stuff it into the long plastic vacuum tube. Once he sufficiently pumped up an erection, he slipped the fitting ring over the base of his penis, showing me with great pride how it produced the desired result. "Voila!" he shouted with joy. But the issues surrounding his no longer producing ejaculate troubled him.

3

Case John

Dr Patti Britton writes:

Over the next few weeks we constructed a plan of action steps that included self-soothing techniques for his anxious self-talk. I taught him to catch himself when he was using self-judging thinking, to refute his inner voice and use positive affirmations, such as “I John am a strong, complete sexual man!” I normalized his feelings then sent him home to conduct a grief ritual for the loss of his ejaculate. In a sacred ceremony he buried his feelings of grief in hand-painted wooden boxes under a grove of elms, while dancing naked on his private property in the moonlight.

4

Case John

Dr Patti Britton writes:

Just weeks later, John had morphed into a dynamic, confident and playful dater, one who never would ejaculate again but felt happy with his sense of self. At the end of our coaching together, John had met a younger woman and they were both becoming comfortable with his pump as a bedside friend during sex, with lasting erections that gave him and his partner pleasure together. This was one “extraordinary” man!

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- What did you notice? What came up for you?



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Sex coaching can take different forms:

- Most use a talk-only approach
- Some utilise body-based or somatic methods
- A growing trend toward an integrated practice, offering sexological bodywork or other forms of appropriate healing touch



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In sex coaching, the client may be invited to show as well as tell. For instance, a coach may hold a mirror for a client to view her own clitoris for the first time or help a male-to-female trans client walk gracefully in her new stilettos.

Personal Preparation

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Three Big Steps

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1. SEXUAL LANGUAGE



- Medical/clinical [often in Latin], such as clitoris, vagina, penis, cunnilingus, fellatio.
- Neutral, such as love button, canal, member, oral sex on her, oral sex on him.
- Slang, such as clit, hole, cock, eating out, going down on.

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- Be able to accept a wide selection of sexual language to do this work effectively.
- Some clients use one or two levels of language; others use all three.
- You must be a safe container for all of their expression, verbal and nonverbal.
- How you respond to John's erectile difficulty can facilitate his healing. If you respond to some words with disgust or shame, you won't be able to hide it from a client.
- I often repeat the words my clients use, starting with the neutral words, and echo their linguistics. That method can help you meet clients where they are and keep the focus on their needs, not yours.

SEXUAL LANGUAGE



Making language distinctions. Sex coaching is non-pathologising, so do reword terms that have a judgmental tone to be more neutral. E.g.

- Wife/girlfriend etc. vs Partner
- Normal vs Natural
- Need vs Want/Desire/Prefer

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SEXUAL LANGUAGE



Making language distinctions.

- Promiscuous vs Sexually experienced
- Safe sex vs Safer Sex
- Preference vs Orientation
- STD vs STI
- Premature ejaculation vs Early ejaculation
- Others?.....

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SEXUAL LANGUAGE



ACTIVITY (Break-out Rooms)

1. First write down five to ten medical/clinical terms (single words or phrases)
2. Next, write down all the slang terms, dirty words, you can for the clinical terms you've given them.
3. Then each person chooses a slang word and invites others in the group to chant, or yell out the slang term they have chosen

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2. DEVELOPING A BASE SEXUAL REPERTOIRE



You owe it to yourself and your clients to free yourself of your own unresolved issues around sex and sexuality. That includes body image issues, sexual inhibitions, or concerns about a sexually past. Engaging in your own personal growth trajectory as a sexual being is a necessary prerequisite for coaching.

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DEVELOPING A BASE SEXUAL REPERTOIRE



Extracurricular activities to consider

- Visiting clubs - strip clubs, exotic dance, pole dancing, burlesque etc.
- Swinging clubs of BDSM venues
- Sexual-spiritual workshops
- Online porn
- Others...?

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3. SEX COACHING ATTITUDES



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Apply a balanced use of right-brain and left-brain tasks.

The left brain = numerically, uses logic, and gathers information.

The right brain = intuition and nonlinear thought, feeling, and sensing—in a word, art.

SEX COACHING ATTITUDES



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Unpack Your Baggage

You don't want to bring your past issues about sex and sexuality into your professional relationships with clients. Find a way to get rid of the baggage and heal your own concerns before you begin practicing.

SEX COACHING ATTITUDES



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Embrace These Qualities

- Tolerance, Patience, Acceptance
- Unconditional love, Liking people, Compassion
- Passion, Honouring humanity

SEX COACHING ATTITUDES



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Embrace These Qualities

- Believing in magic/knowing that miracles can happen
- Forgiveness, Understanding, Playfulness
- Lightness of being, Quick wit, Intensity

SEX COACHING ATTITUDES



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Embrace These Qualities

- Laser-like thinking
- Articulateness/good communication
- Sensitivity, High hopes

SEX COACHING ATTITUDES



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Embrace These Qualities

- Taking a stand for the clients' greatest good
- Taking a stand for your greatest good
- Keeping tight and clean boundaries

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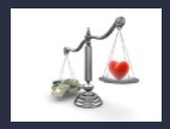
SEX COACHING ATTITUDES



Embrace These Qualities

- Showing up (on time) and being fully present
- Keeping a “no matter what” affect
- Upholding “act as if” as an art form
- Adopting an “up until now” approach

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Values, Beliefs, Feelings & Attitudes

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The Girl and The Sailor - Case Study

A ship sank in a storm. Five survivors scrambled aboard two lifeboats: a sailor, a girl, and an old man in one boat; the girl’s fiancé and his best friend in the second. That evening the storm continued, and the two boats separated. The one with the sailor, the girl, and the old man washed ashore on an island and was wrecked.

The next day the weather cleared, and still the girl could not locate her fiancé. In the distance she saw another island. Hoping to find her fiancé, she begged the sailor to repair the boat and row her to the other island. The sailor agreed, on the condition that she slept with him that night.

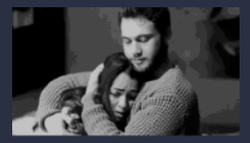


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The Girl and The Sailor - Case Study

Distraught, she went to the old man for advice. “I can’t tell you what’s right or wrong for you,” he said. “Look into your heart and follow it.” Confused but desperate, she agreed to the sailor’s condition. The next morning the sailor fixed the boat and rowed her to the other island. Jumping out of the boat, she ran up the beach into the arms of her fiancé.

Then she decided to tell him about the previous night. In a rage, he pushed her aside and said, “Get away from me! I don’t want to see you again!” Weeping, she started to walk slowly down the beach. Her fiancé’s best friend saw her and went to her, put an arm around her, and said, “I can tell that you two have had a fight. I’ll try to patch it up, but in the meantime I’ll take care of you.”



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COURAGEOUS CONVERSATIONS

Moral, Intellectual, Emotional and Social Reactions

BREAK-OUT ROOMS -

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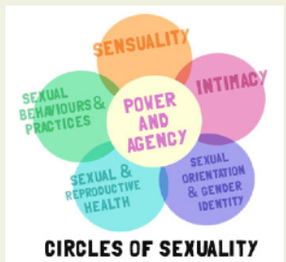
Professional Preparation

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Knowledge, Resources, Failures

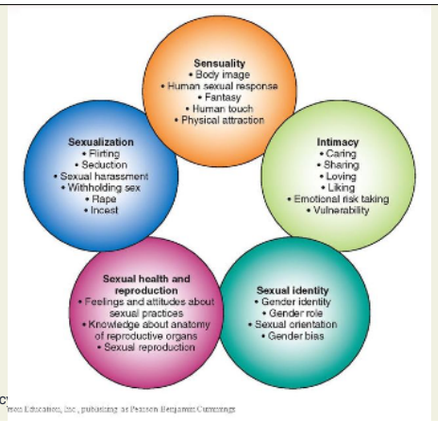
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CIRCLES OF SEXUALITY





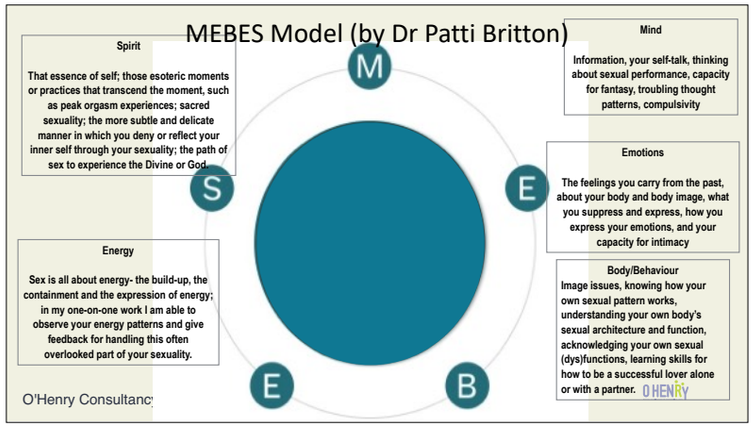
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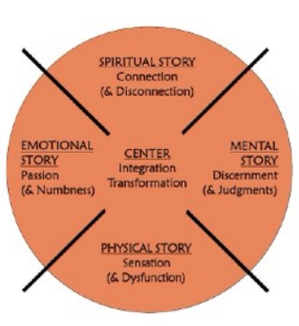
PLISSIT

- P: PERMISSION
- LI: LIMITED INFORMATION (Sex Education stops here)
- SS: SPECIFIC SUGGESTIONS
- IT: INTENSIVE THERAPY (In Sex Coaching, IC is used for INTENSIVE COACHING)

MEBES Model (by Dr Patti Britton)



4D WHEEL OF SEXUAL EXPERIENCE



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Basic Guidelines for Sex Coaching

1. **Go beyond the personal** - coaching skills, knowledge of sexual concerns, contacts, referrals and connections.

2. **Sex Education - A.B.Cs of sex** - excellent books, DVDs, videos, websites, and courses (You're already in a great one!)

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Basic Guidelines for Sex Coaching

- **Sexual Attitude Reassessment (SAR)** Standards - a process-oriented, structured group experience that promotes participants' awareness of their attitudes and values related to sexuality and assists them in understanding how these attitudes and values affect them professionally and personally.

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Basic Guidelines for Sex Coaching

- **Sexual Attitude Reassessment (SAR) -** the primary purpose = the examination of attitudes and values; **NOT** a traditional academic experience designed to disseminate cognitive information, **NOR** is it psychotherapy directed toward the resolution of personal problems.

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Basic Guidelines for Sex Coaching

Sexual Attitude Reassessment (SAR) -

- Exposure to a wide spectrum of human sexual arousal and behaviour, followed by the opportunity to express feelings regarding the range of human sexuality, including the identification of areas of comfort & discomfort

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Basic Guidelines for Sex Coaching

Sexual Attitude Reassessment (SAR) -

- Exploration of participants' attitudes and biases related to various sexual expressions and how these attitudes and biases may affect personal expression and professional interventions

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Basic Guidelines for Sex Coaching

Sexual Attitude Reassessment (SAR) -

- Increasing participants' comfort in discussing sexual matters
- Providing a nonjudgmental and respectful forum for the exploration of others' sexual values and differences

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Basic Guidelines for Sex Coaching

Sexual Attitude Reassessment (SAR) -

- The opportunity to better understand the sexual attitudes and values of persons whose sexual interests or physical or cognitive abilities are different from those of the participant

Basic Guidelines for Sex Coaching

Sexual Attitude Reassessment (SAR) -
Includes mandatory topics & electives.
Mandatory:

- Masturbation
- Sexual orientation
- Sexuality across the lifespan
- Sexual variations

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Basic Guidelines for Sex Coaching

Sexual Attitude Reassessment (SAR) -
Includes mandatory topics & electives.
Mandatory:

- Sexual variations
- Sexual ethics and morals
- Sexuality and physical and developmental disability
- Negative sexual experiences

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Basic Guidelines for Sex Coaching

Clinical Skills, Anatomy, Legal Issues

- Choosing appropriate intervention
- Traditional therapy vs coaching
- Competency in taking a complete sexual history & protect client identity
- Knowledge of developmental sexology (sex across the life span)

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Basic Guidelines for Sex Coaching

Clinical Skills, Anatomy, Legal Issues

- Competency to deal with the situational factors that affect sexual values, sexual situations, and sexual functioning
- Anatomy & physiology skills (e.g. genitals, sexual response cycle, etc.)

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Basic Guidelines for Sex Coaching

Clinical Skills, Anatomy, Legal Issues

- Competency to be able to sort out and interpret the various legal responsibilities of a sexologist

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Basic Guidelines for Sex Coaching

Governing bodies

- Organisations that set the standards, do research and reports, create policy, do advocacy & training. (E.g. Planned Parenthood, SIECUS (Sexuality Information and Education Council of the United States), World Association of Sexology, World Health Organisation)

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Basic Guidelines for Sex Coaching

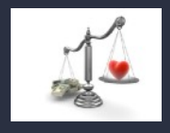
3. **Understanding Sexual Diversity** - Learn about an array of sexual behaviours and a wide range of human sexual expression, along with differing viewpoints, attitudes, and ideas. Go beyond reading, go to places and events where you can meet people who are different from you in sexual orientation and proclivity. Sexuality evolves from a context. Attend conferences, etc.

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Basic Guidelines for Sex Coaching

4. **Think Outside the Box** - Give yourself permission not to do it the way others have done it before. Dare to use techniques, approaches, exercises, recommended resources, and even your own personality that is not the 'regular' or 'usual' way. Incorporate other non-sex related skills you may have.

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When Sex Coaching Fails

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What Might Failure Look Like

As with life itself, sometimes things just don't happen the way you wish.

- Sometimes it is a client with whom you don't click
- A client who simply cannot seem to budge from along his own continuum.

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What Might Failure Look Like

- Other times it's more subtle—a feeling you get or a pattern of missed appointments that gives you the sense, usually accurately, that this isn't working for you or the client.

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What Might Failure Look Like

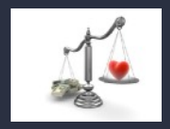
- You did your best and progress is not being made (it may be that the terror of facing the truth, and the compelling need to make a significant change, is the point of no return for a client.)

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What Might Failure Look Like

- Consider the Pleasure-Pain continuum: people are pain avoiders as much as they are pleasure seekers. Someone may quit when they can't face the pain of real change. The pain of change seems to exceed the reward (pleasure) Sometimes the ones who quit—our 'failures—leave the sex coaching process early on but return again later.

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Where are you now?

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CIRCLES OF SEXUALITY WORKSHEET

Let's explore where you are now in terms of the topics on the Circles of Sexuality diagram

NOTICE, FEEL, THINK

- What's happening in your body? Has anything shifted?
- What emotions are coming up for you?
- What are your thoughts and beliefs about yourself going forward, or about this work in general?
- Is there a movement or gesture your body wants to do now, along with words?

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